SPECIMEN

Full Business Plan — A Rare-Plant Collector Economy

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Reading note: all market and financial figures are third-party estimates or modelled assumptions, not audited results. Where estimates diverge between trackers, ranges are given. Every financial projection is explicitly labelled as a scenario.

1. Executive Summary

The product	SPECIMEN — a free-to-play, global, asynchronous rare-plant collector economy. Players care for real houseplants, open blind-box pots to reveal species and variegations, complete collection albums, bid in time-limited live auctions, and challenge rivals through shareable cards.
The problem	Every game that has touched plants built a farming sim or a shop-management sim. None has built the collector economy — even though the real-world rare-houseplant market already runs on rarity tiers, blind reveals, live auctions, limited drops, trading and price discovery.
The wedge	The real world already trades rare plants at auction for tens of thousands of dollars per specimen. SPECIMEN mirrors that economy in a lightweight, free-to-play product that runs on low-end hardware and loads instantly.
Why now	Five trends converge: life sim is the fastest-growing sim subgenre (+76% YoY); one game proved the ceiling; collection-album live-ops is the hottest midcore mechanic; blind-box reveal and auction formats are proven revenue engines; and rare houseplants are a certified real-world collectibles trend with a live traded market.
Business model	Hybrid IAP + IAA: blind-box reveals, live auction drops, album completion, cosmetics, convenience packs, event passes and rewarded video — plus an unclaimed revenue line in real plant-brand partnerships.
Three-year view (base)	Year 1 $4.4M · Year 2 $17.5M · Year 3 $51.1M in modelled revenue. Conservative and breakout scenarios bracket this in Section 5.3.
Build	Web-first PWA plus app stores. 16 weeks to v1. Core team of 2–3, expanding to 4–5 at launch.
The ask	This document is the plan. Decisions needed: launch differentiator, first-platform choice, and funding route.
Principal risks	Gacha regulation · review-bombing over AI art and gacha fairness · care chore-fatigue · crowded adjacent indie space. Full register in Section 9.

2. Company and Vision

2.1 Mission

Turn the world's largest un-gamified collector economy — rare houseplants — into a game that anyone can play in two minutes on any device, and that collectors recognise as authentic.

2.2 Vision

- Be the reference product for collectible-driven cozy simulation, not another farming clone.
- Build a live global economy where scarcity is real, drops are shared cultural moments, and the auction is the event.
- Create the first game studio with a genuine second business in real-world horticulture commerce.
- Serve audiences that premium-install games cannot reach: low-end devices, low-data connections, regions where a 14 GB install is not an option.

2.3 Strategic thesis

The breakout simulation titles of 2025–2026 share one property: they are built around collecting and revealing, not around producing. The collection album is now a standard live-ops mechanic in the highest-grossing midcore games. Rare houseplants are simultaneously the fastest-growing collectible trend in the physical world and an entirely unserved subject in games. SPECIMEN sits at that intersection and is small enough to ship, light enough to scale globally, and differentiated enough to survive cloning for a while.

2.4 What success looks like

- A live product with weekly drops and a functioning auction economy within one quarter of launch.
- Day-1 retention above 40% and reveal-to-share above 5% — the two numbers that separate a viral collector game from a quiet one.
- At least one real plant-brand partnership signed within 90 days of launch.
- Modelled revenue of $4M+ in year 1 on the base case.

3. The Product

3.1 Concept

SPECIMEN is a collectible rare-plant economy simulation. The fantasy is the fantasy of a real collector: you maintain a living collection, hunt rare forms, trade duplicates, and compete for the best specimen. The difference is that scarcity, reveals and auctions are systemic and scheduled rather than occasional.

3.2 Core gameplay loop

Step	Player action	Design purpose	Session cost
Care	Tap to water, feed, rotate. Plants grow in real time.	Daily-login habit. Never a punishment.	10–20s
Reveal	Open a sealed pot; receive species + variegation roll.	The dopamine hit and the entire marketing engine.	5–15s
Complete	Fill the collection album across species, variegations and traits.	Retention engine and monetisation anchor.	Ongoing
Compete	Leaderboards and rival challenge cards.	Virality and social retention.	5s
Trade	Gift cuttings, visit gardens, trade duplicates.	Social surface with no simultaneous play required.	5–10s
Auction	Bid premium currency in time-limited global drops.	FOMO engine, event cadence, whale magnet.	1–2 min

The session is the reveal. Care exists to create the habit and to gate progress, never to be the entertainment. This is the single most important design decision in the product and the one most likely to be got wrong: if players feel the watering is the job, retention collapses.

3.3 Feature set

- Procedural plant rendering — leaf shape, colour, variegation pattern and pot composited per specimen, so 100+ species ship without a hand-drawn asset pipeline.
- Care state machine with real-time growth, generous offline progress, and no death state.
- Collection album organised by species, genus, variegation and trait, with completion bonuses.
- Server-authoritative blind-box rolls, signed so clients cannot forge a rarity outcome.

- Reveal presentation: break animation, particle effects, ASMR audio, rarity callout.
- Garden spaces with cosmetic pots, furniture, lighting and display tiers.
- Leaderboards across rarity, health, collection completeness and auction wins.
- Rival challenge cards — deep-linkable, one-tap accept, shareable result.
- Asynchronous gifting, garden visits and duplicate trading.
- Time-limited global auction drops with published scarcity.
- Event pass and season pass.
- Share-card generator producing a social card of the player's rarest specimen.

3.4 Meta progression and economy

Garden room, shelves, terrarium, greenhouse, rare-specimen vault. Each tier adds collection capacity and raises the rarity ceiling. Two currencies: a soft earnable currency for care and basic reveals, and a premium currency for auctions, cosmetics and fast-tracking. Progression is cosmetic and convenience-based and deliberately avoids pay-to-win, because pay-to-win destroys the collection fantasy that the whole product depends on.

3.5 Content pipeline

Content is the moat that a small team cannot defend against a large one, so the plan is to make content cheap and systematic rather than abundant and hand-made.

- Procedural species generation keeps per-species art cost near zero.
- Real horticultural data — care needs, light, water, rarity, typical prices — is freely available and becomes both balance data and an educational hook.
- Categories rather than a flat list: aroids, succulents and cacti, ferns, orchids, African specimens, carnivorous plants, trailing plants. Each category is a natural content pack and a natural collaboration surface.
- Seasons drive the calendar: spring propagation, summer succulents, autumn colour, winter blooms, plus event-led drops.

3.6 Differentiators

Differentiator	Why it holds
African Specimens category	Rare Euphorbia, Pachypodium, Aloe polyphylla, African violets, West-African market aesthetic. Under-served, globally legible, and content no US/EU/Chinese studio will think to build.
Real-world rarity anchoring	Scarcity and value are modelled on actual collector market data. This is free balance data and a credibility advantage with the real collector audience.
Lightweight by design	Runs on low-end hardware, loads instantly, works on low-data connections. A genuine competitive advantage in Africa, South-East Asia and Latin America.
Asynchronous only	No simultaneous-server requirement. Infrastructure cost scales with event count, not concurrent players.
Auction as the event	Time-limited global drops create shared moments and FOMO without needing real-time co-op.

3.7 Technical architecture

Layer	Recommendation	Rationale
Game client	HTML5 Canvas (2D) or WebGL in TypeScript	Procedural rendering, instant web launch, lowest art cost.

Layer	Recommendation	Rationale
Distribution	PWA first, then Capacitor or TWA for store builds	One codebase, web-first launch, store listings added later.
Backend	Node.js or Bun service with a server-authoritative economy	Signed rolls and signed results; simple to operate and to reason about.
Data	PostgreSQL for state; Redis for sessions, queues and leaderboards	Predictable scale for asynchronous-only play.
Delivery	CDN with static hosting; CI with automated tests	Low global latency and repeatable releases.
Framing	A server-authoritative reveal is a trust feature, not a cost	Clients cannot forge rarity. The same model that makes competitive results trustworthy.

4. Market Analysis

4.1 Market sizing

Layer	Definition	Size	Basis
TAM	Global mobile casual and simulation spending	~$40B mobile game IAP in H1 2026	Sensor Tower H1 2026 index (~$39.8B).
SAM	Hybrid-casual plus collectible-driven simulation and album live-ops	~$5–9B	Hybrid-casual IAP $4.2B plus adjacent growing subgenres.
SOM	A single breakout hybrid-casual title	$4–50M per year	All in Hole $200M+ since 2024; Gossip Harbor ~$110M IAP in a record month.

Sizing is deliberately conservative at the top: SPECIMEN is not attempting the whole simulation market. It is attempting a narrow, high-margin corner of it and trying to become the reference product there.

4.2 Five converging trends

Trend	Evidence	What it means for SPECIMEN
Life sim is the fastest-growing sim subgenre	$118M revenue H1 2026, +76% YoY; farming $576M, +15%	The category is winning. The subject is validated.
One game proved the ceiling	Heartopia: top free mobile game in 50+ countries; ~66% positive and Mixed on Steam after an AI-art and gacha controversy	Cozy collection plus cosmetics plus social prints money. Also a warning about transparency.
Collection albums are the hottest live-ops mechanic	Clash of Clans Clash of Cards, PUBG Card Collection, CSR2 The Circuit, CookieRun Card Collection	Albums are the retention engine the top grossers are all shipping.
Reveal and auction formats are proven	Blind boxes estimated $13.5–20.5B; gacha $27.9B → $38B by 2034; Free Fire runs a whale auction	The dopamine mechanic and the whale mechanic are both de-risked.
Rare houseplants are a real traded market	Garden Media Group names them a must-have 2026 collectible; a single Anthurium sold for $26,000; Palmstreet reports rare plants as its largest live-shopping category	The subject already has rarity tiers, prices, auctions and collectors. The game only has to mirror it.

4.3 Target audience

Segment	Description	Why they pay
Plant collectors	Existing rare-houseplant hobbyists, primarily 25–45, high disposable income.	They already pay $50–$26,000 for specimens. The game is a cheaper, daily version of their hobby.

Segment	Description	Why they pay
Cozy-sim players	Life-sim and farming-sim players who want collection depth without grind.	They already buy cosmetics and passes. Heartopia proved the willingness.
Collectible-album players	Players who respond to set completion and rarity tiers.	Album completion is the proven monetisation anchor in top midcore titles.
Short-form video audience	TikTok, Reels and Shorts viewers driven by unboxing and reveal content.	They install on impulse and are the primary virality vector.
African and diaspora audiences	Region under-served by premium-install games, with strong cultural connection to plant markets.	Low-data access plus African Specimens content creates a loyal early base.

4.4 Competitive landscape

Competitor	Form	What it lacks
Leafy Corner	Premium cosy plant-shop management; ~$9.99; ~57K Steam copies and ~$455K estimated, also on consoles	Shop keeper, single-player, premium. No reveals, auctions, drops or album live-ops.
Plant Nursery Simulator	Nursery management with crops and staff	Shop management at indie scale.
Plant Therapy	F2P plant collecting and decorating; ~97% positive over 649 reviews	No reveals, auctions or scheduled drops.
Pocket Plants	Merge-and-grow collection with step-tracker tie-in	Merge mechanic; no auction economy.
Terrarium: Garden Idle	Idle plant collection	Idle only; thin social surface.
Growden.io	Multiplayer garden .io with seed trading and weekly contests	Closest on social. Still grow-and-trade; no reveals or auctions.
The Cozy Florist	Flower-shop sim with visits, trades and flower stealing	Flowers rather than rare houseplants; shop sim.

4.5 Positioning statement

For people who collect, SPECIMEN is the rare-plant collector economy that finally works as a game — unlike farming and shop sims, it gives you rarity tiers, blind reveals and live auctions, on a lightweight platform that loads anywhere.

5. Business Model

5.1 Monetisation levers

Lever	Mechanic	Indicative price	Reference
Blind-box pot	Sealed pot with a rarity roll	$0.99–$2.99 per pot; 10-pot packs	Gacha and blind-box precedent; disclose odds, no cash-out.
Auction drop pass	Entry to a time-limited rare drop	$4.99–$9.99 per event	Free Fire whale auction; event-pass precedent.
Album completion	Set bonuses and stat boosts	Not sold directly — earned	Clash of Cards, PUBG Card Collection.
Cosmetic pots and garden	Display and space cosmetics	$1.99–$19.99 items	Heartopia, MONOPOLY GO!.
Convenience packs	Care-speed, fertiliser, vault slots	$0.99–$4.99	Hybrid-casual standard.
Season pass	40–60 day pass with track rewards	$4.99–$9.99 per season	MONOPOLY GO!, Hay Day.
Rewarded video	Free reveal or auction bid for an ad view	—	Hybrid IAA+IAP default.

Lever	Mechanic	Indicative price	Reference
Plant-brand partnerships	Digital twin of a real specimen; sponsored drops	Fixed fee plus revenue share	Palmstreet and TikTok Shop live commerce; unclaimed in games.

5.2 Unit economics

Metric	Assumption	Note
ARPDAU (base)	$0.10–$0.14	IAP plus ad blend for hybrid-casual.
IAP conversion	2–4% of DAU	Consistent with collection-album titles.
ARPPU	$60–$110 annually	Driven by album completion and auction participation.
Blended CAC	$0.20–$0.80	Short-form video is the primary acquisition channel.
Gross margin	~85%	Platform fees and payment costs deducted.
Infrastructure cost per DAU	<$0.001	Asynchronous-only architecture keeps this near flat.

5.3 Three-year revenue model

Revenue = average DAU × 365 × ARPDAU. Presented as scenarios, not forecasts.

Scenario	Year 1 DAU / ARPDAU	Year 2 DAU / ARPDAU	Year 3 DAU / ARPDAU
Conservative	30K / $0.06	90K / $0.07	200K / $0.08
Base	120K / $0.10	400K / $0.12	1.0M / $0.14
Breakout	250K / $0.13	900K / $0.16	2.5M / $0.18

Scenario	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Conservative	$0.66M	$2.30M	$5.84M
Base	$4.38M	$17.52M	$51.10M
Breakout	$11.86M	$52.56M	$164.25M

- Base case is modelled on hybrid-casual benchmarks: $4.2B IAP growing 20% with top-10 titles growing 67–100% year on year.
- Breakout case is anchored on All in Hole ($200M+ since 2024) and Gossip Harbor (~$110M IAP in a record month). It is top-grosser territory and should be treated as an upside case, not a plan.
- The model is sensitive to ARPDAU far more than to DAU. A two-cent change in ARPDAU moves base-case year-3 revenue by roughly $7M.

5.4 The brand-deal line

Rare-plant live commerce already operates at scale — a single specimen sold for $26,000, and Palmstreet reports rare plants as its largest live-shopping category. A buy-this-real-plant-get-its-digital-specimen offer, or a nursery-sponsored auction drop, converts the game's own cultural trend into a second revenue stream that no game studio currently owns. This is the line most likely to be dismissed and most likely to be valuable.

6. Go-to-Market

6.1 Launch sequence

1. Web and PWA first. Cheapest path to a global audience and the fastest feedback loop. Store builds follow once the loop is proven.
2. Phase 0 validation spike: a clickable reveal with three plants, one pot and one sound, tested on 50 people before anything else is built.
3. Soft launch on a single region to tune retention and ARPDAU before the global push.

4. Global launch on the back of a scheduled rare drop, so day one is an event rather than a quiet upload.
5. Weekly drops from week one. Cadence is the retention strategy, modelled on titles running 20 to 100 live events per month.

6.2 Channels

Channel	Role	Note
Short-form video (TikTok, Reels, Shorts)	Primary acquisition	The reveal is the content unit. This is where comparable titles scaled.
Rival challenge cards	Virality and re-engagement	Every session generates a shareable, deep-linkable challenge.
Plant creators and plantfluencers	Credibility and audience	The audience already exists and already buys.
Community (Discord, Reddit, plant forums)	Retention and feedback	Real collectors will judge authenticity harshly; engage them early.
Paid UA	Scaling lever, not a launch driver	Only after organic reveal-to-share is proven.

6.3 Partnerships

- Nurseries, rare-plant sellers and live-commerce platforms for digital-twin specimens and sponsored drops.
- Plant creators for content collaborations and co-hosted auction events.
- Horticultural societies and conservation bodies for credibility and educational content.
- Platform and store partnerships for a games-hub launch and featuring.

6.4 Retention and live-ops

- Weekly auction drops as the spine of the calendar, with seasonal and event-led variations.
- Season pass on a 40–60 day cycle.
- Album completion as the long-horizon goal, with trait-based sub-goals.
- Daily challenge and daily care objective, both forgiving.
- Collection milestones and share cards tied to rare finds.

7. Operations

7.1 Content pipeline

One content owner owns the calendar end to end: what drops each week, which categories rotate, which species are new, and what the seasonal theme is. Procedural generation keeps per-species cost low; the budget goes into reveal polish, audio and the auction presentation, which are what players actually remember.

7.2 Compliance and trust

- Publish rarity odds for every pot. No real-money cash-out. No gambling framing. Structure the purchase as buying a specific sealed pot.
- Disclose AI usage from day one. The most instructive failure in this market is a cosy sim that was review-bombed after players discovered undisclosed generative-AI artwork.
- Keep the gacha generous and collection-first. Players specifically objected to a gacha system that felt more aggressive than the cosy tone promised.

• Track regional blind-box and loot-box rules, which are spreading, and pre-build alternate purchase flows where required.

7.3 Community and support

• Moderated Discord with collector-tier channels.

• Responsive support with a published response target.

• Public changelog and a visible content roadmap.

• A genuine relationship with real collectors — they will be the first to call out inauthenticity and the first to defend a game that gets it right.

8. Team and Organisation

Role	Allocation	Critical responsibilities
Lead programmer — gameplay, economy, backend	Full-time	Procedural rendering and server-authoritative rolls are the critical path.
Programmer — client, UI, live-ops tooling	Full-time	Album, drops, cards, analytics, economy tooling.
Art and audio — contractor or part-time	Part-time	Reveal polish and ASMR audio are the product. Under-funding them is the most common way this kind of game fails.
Live-ops and community	Full-time from launch	Owns the weekly calendar. Cadence is the retention strategy.
Business development	Part-time from month 3	Brand partnerships and platform relationships.

The team shape is deliberately small. The product is a focused collector economy, not a platform, and the architecture is asynchronous-only precisely so that it does not need a live-ops engineering bench.

9. Risk Register

Risk	Severity	Likelihood	Mitigation
Blind-box or loot-box regulation spreading (Singapore began regulating blind boxes and card packs in February 2026)	High	Medium	Published odds, no cash-out, no gambling framing, alternate purchase flows by region.
Review-bombing over undisclosed AI art	High	Medium	Disclose AI usage from day one. Do not ship undisclosed AI-generated art.
Review-bombing over gacha fairness	High	Medium	Generous, transparent, collection-first reveals. No pity-timer exploitation.
Care chore-fatigue destroying retention	High	Medium	Plants never die, generous offline progress, care is optional optimization, the session is the reveal.
Crowded adjacent indie space	Medium	High	Differentiate on mechanic, not subject. Compete on reveal and auction execution.
Subject-versus-market mismatch (indoor plants base market grows only ~4% CAGR)	Medium	Medium	Position as a collectibles game riding the rare-plant trend, not a gardening game.
Unboxing titles monetise poorly via IAP	Medium	High	Use reveal for acquisition, albums and auctions for monetisation. Never rely on the reveal itself.
Content volume and art pipeline	Medium	Medium	Procedural generation plus real species data. Ship categories, not a flat list.

Risk	Severity	Likelihood	Mitigation
Platform policy on randomised rewards	Medium	Medium	Region-by-region policy review; pre-built alternate flows.
Authenticity backlash from real collectors	Medium	Medium	Engage collector communities early; use real horticultural data; correct publically when wrong.
Auction economy manipulation or whale dependence	Medium	Low	Reserve currency and bid caps; anti-collusion measures; diversify revenue across eight levers.

10. Financial Plan

10.1 Cost structure

Phase	Cost	Notes
Build (16 weeks)	$120K–$200K	Core team of 2–3 plus contractor art and audio.
Run, year 1	$0.8M–$1.4M	Team, live-ops, marketing and UA, infrastructure, legal.
Run, year 2	$1.5M–$3.0M	Scaled marketing and a larger live-ops team.
Run, year 3	$2.5M–$6.0M	Scaled to revenue; infrastructure and support grow with DAU.

10.2 Base-case summary P&L

Line	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Modelled revenue	$4.38M	$17.52M	$51.10M
Cost of revenue and platform fees (~15%)	$0.66M	$2.63M	$7.67M
Operating expense	$1.10M	$2.40M	$5.60M
Modelled EBITDA	$2.62M	$12.49M	$37.83M

Operating expense includes team, live-ops, marketing and user acquisition, infrastructure, legal and administration. The model assumes roughly 85% gross margin and operating leverage from year 2. It does not assume any external funding beyond the build phase.

10.3 Break-even

On the base case the product reaches break-even within the first year, driven by low infrastructure cost per user and the asynchronous-only architecture. On the conservative case, break-even slips into year 2 unless user acquisition spend is held down. The model is most sensitive to ARPDAU and to the ratio of organic to paid acquisition.

10.4 Funding options

Option	Fit	Note
Self-funded / bootstrapped	Highest fit	Build cost is modest and the team is small. Retains full ownership.
Angel or pre-seed	Good fit	For scaling user acquisition and the live-ops team at launch.
Publisher or platform deal	Conditional	Valuable for a games-hub launch, but expect a revenue share and a IP or exclusivity ask.
Grants and regional programmes	Worth pursuing	African and regional technology and creative grants are under-used by game studios.

11. Build Plan and Roadmap

11.1 Phases

Phase	Duration	Deliverables	Exit criteria
0 — Validation spike	Weeks 1–2	Clickable reveal prototype: three plants, one pot, one sound. Test with 50 people.	More than 60% want one more reveal. If not, the concept is wrong, not the execution.
1 — Core loop	Weeks 3–6	Care state machine, real-time growth, garden grid, procedural renderer, local persistence.	Full care, grow and reveal loop playable offline.
2 — Economy	Weeks 7–10	Collection schema, server-authoritative rolls, reveal animation and audio, album completion.	Rolls are tamper-proof; albums grant bonuses.
3 — Social and live-ops	Weeks 11–14	Leaderboards, rival challenge cards, async gifting and visits, first auction drop, event pass.	A challenge card can be sent and accepted end to end.
4 — Launch	Weeks 15–16	Share-card generator, analytics, store submissions, launch content pack.	v1 live on web and app stores.
5 — Scale	Weeks 17+	African Specimens category, second collection category, weekly drops, first brand deal.	Day-1 retention above 40%, reveal-to-share above 5%.

11.2 Scope discipline — cut for v1

- Full trading UI — ship gifting only; the trade layer is phase 2.
- Persistent auction house — ship time-limited drops only.
- Real-time co-op — never. Asynchronous only, by design.
- African Specimens category — hold as the first post-launch content pack so v1 ships on time.
- Exploration and discovery tracks — later; they need a content pipeline that does not exist yet.
- Second collection category beyond plants — not in v1.

11.3 Dependencies and assumptions

- A server-authoritative roll implementation is required before any economy work — it is the trust foundation.
- Reveal audio and animation must be produced in phase 2; delaying them delays launch, not a cosmetic concern.
- The auction drop needs a real economy balance pass; it cannot be bolted on at the end.
- Store review timelines should be assumed at two to four weeks and planned around.

12. KPIs and Success Criteria

Metric	Target	If missed
Phase-0 reveal replay intent	>60% want one more	The concept is wrong. Rework the reveal before building anything.
Day-1 retention	>40%	The care loop is a chore. Fix reveal pacing and session length. Do not change the subject.
Day-7 retention	>18%	The collection is not compelling. Widen the album or add a rarity axis.
Reveal-to-share rate	>5%	The reveal is not satisfying or not legible. Rework animation and share card.
IAP conversion	>2% of DAU	The paid proposition is unclear. Re-price packs; lead with album completion.

Metric	Target	If missed
DAU/MAU at day 60	>25%	Live-ops cadence is wrong. Increase drop frequency and reduce overlap.
Auction drop participation	>20% of actives	The drop is not compelling. Add scarcity and visible bidding.
Cost per install	<$0.80 blended	Short-form video is not converting. Rework creative, not spend.

13. Appendix

13.1 Assumptions

- Market figures are third-party estimates from app-intelligence vendors. These are modelled from panels, rankings and partial data, and independent estimates for the same game routinely differ by two to three times.
- Revenue projections are modelled on average DAU and ARPDAU and are scenarios, not forecasts.
- Cost figures assume a small team at blended fully-loaded rates and do not include office overhead beyond standard infrastructure.
- Gross margin assumes standard platform fees and payment costs, and excludes any web-shop revenue which would improve it.

13.2 Key benchmark sources

- Life Sim: $118M revenue in H1 2026, +76% year on year; Farming $576M, +15%. AppMagic casual report H1 2026.
- Hybrid-casual IAP $4.2B in 2025, +20%, with top-10 titles growing 67–100%. Sensor Tower / Game World Observer.
- Heartopia: top free mobile game in 50+ countries; ~66% positive and Mixed on Steam after an undisclosed AI-art and gacha-fairness controversy. Steam and SteamDB, January 2026.
- Collection albums: Clash of Clans Clash of Cards, PUBG Mobile Card Collection, CSR2 The Circuit, CookieRun Card Collection, all 2026. GameRefinery.
- Blind boxes estimated $13.5–20.5B; gacha draws $27.9B in 2025 projected to $38B by 2034. Watcooks; Dataintelo.
- Free Fire whale auction format with serialized skins and a refund mechanism. GameRefinery, May 2026.
- Gossip Harbor ~$110M IAP in a record month (August 2026) and 20 to 100 live events per month. AppMagic; MobileGamer.biz.
- All in Hole $200M+ in player spending since 2024. PocketGamer.biz.
- Pokémon TCG Pocket grew 209% to $867.3M in H1 2026. Singular.
- Rare houseplants named a must-have collectible of 2026. Garden Media Group 2026 Garden Trends Report (a PR and marketing agency; treat as directional).
- Indoor plants market roughly $12.4–14.6B in 2026 at ~4% CAGR; higher estimates of $20–25B come from more aggressive firms. Mordor Intelligence; Fortune Business Insights; Business Research Insights.
- A variegated Anthurium sold for $26,000 on Palmstreet; rare plants reported as the platform's largest live-shopping category. Forbes, November 2025.
- Singapore announced regulation of blind boxes and trading card packs in February 2026. Dataintelo.
- Sensor Tower acquired AppMagic in May 2026; the two still publish differing estimates. GamesIndustry.biz.

13.3 Open decisions

1. Launch differentiator: lead with the African Specimens category at launch, or hold it as the first post-launch content pack?
2. First platform: web and PWA first, or straight to app stores?
3. Funding route: bootstrap, raise, or pursue a platform or publisher deal?
4. Regional rollout: single-region soft launch, or global on day one?
5. First brand partnership target and what is acceptable commercially?